they accepted her readily too and we thought others would too. But the social exclusion our daughter has faced has been shocking," says Kapoor.

On June 14, the Supreme Court came up with a historic verdict—children born to couples living together for a considerable period will be entitled to inherit ancestral property. The ruling has built on an earlier pronouncement acknowledging the legitimacy of children of unmarried parents, almost a decade ago. But the new division bench order of Justices Abdul Nazeer and Vikram Nath at the apex court took the recognition a notch further by guaranteeing them inheritance rights.

For Safeen Iqbal and Varun Kapoor, the judgment came as both affirmation and sweet relief. "The court ruling is life-altering," says Kapoor. "Of course, those unmarried but dating should have the right to have children and live with dignity. Many today don't believe in the institution of marriage, why should their children suffer as a result of their beliefs?" Others in the legal community have welcomed the move as another important but incremental step towards justice and a freedom from stigma and discrimination for parents and children who have lived together without the religious or legal ceremony of marriage.

But what the law has done, will society do as easily? Prasanto Ray, social scientist and professor emeritus at Presidency University, Kolkata, does not think so. "Passing a judgment or an act is one thing, but assimilating it in social life first as practice and then as social behaviour quite another. It cannot happen overnight."

Pablo and Aruna (*both names changed*), scholars at a reputed university in the UK, are discovering this the hard way. Coming home to India after three years, they are bringing with them their three-year-old daughter, to introduce her to her grandparents and the extended family. However, far from looking forward to the prospect, Pablo's parents, the Mukherjees, are apprehensive. The unmarried status



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

A SUPREME COURT BENCH HAS RULED THAT IF A MAN AND WOMAN HAVE LIVED TOGETHER FOR A CONSIDERABLE PERIOD, THEY WILL BE PRESUMED TO BE MARRIED AND THEIR CHILDREN CANNOT BE DENIED THE RIGHT TO INHERITANCE